strike that Kennedy had favored from the very beginning, not the extensive one covering airplanes and other installations advocated by the chiefs.[22]

On the morning of Monday, October 22, after having reviewed his options once again with his advisers, John Kennedy placed a call to his predecessor Dwight Eisenhower. The general was supportive of the blockade option but clearly looked at it as a prelude to the invasion. He dismissed Kennedy's concerns that Khrushchev could attack West Berlin or use nuclear weapons in response to the invasion of the island. "Something may make these people shoot them off," remarked Eisenhower with reference to the Soviet nuclear weapons. "I just don't believe this will." "Yeh, right," responded Kennedy with a chuckle. He was not convinced.[23]

At 7:00 p.m., after informing the leadership of the Senate and the House of Representatives on Monday afternoon about the burgeoning crisis and his plan to impose a blockade of Cuba, Kennedy went in front of television cameras to deliver his address to the nation. "Good evening, my fellow citizens," he began in a somber tone, projecting a sense of urgency but also resolve and self-confidence. "Within the past week unmistakable evidence has established the fact that a series of offensive missile sites is now in preparation on that imprisoned island. The purpose of these bases can be none other than to provide a nuclear strike capability against the Western hemisphere." He warned Khrushchev that a nuclear missile fired from Cuba would be met with "full retaliatory response upon the Soviet Union."

Kennedy announced seven steps he was taking to protect the United States from the imminent threat posed by the missiles. The first was the declaration of a "strict quarantine on all offensive military equipment" being shipped to Cuba. Concerned more than ever about the possibility of Soviet retaliatory action in Berlin, Kennedy pointed out the limited character of the blockade: "We are not at this time, however, denying the necessities of life as the Soviets attempted to do in their Berlin blockade of 1948." The seventh and last point contained a demand to Khrushchev. "I call upon Chairman Khrushchev," declared Kennedy, "to halt and eliminate this clandestine, reckless, and provocative threat to world peace and to stable relations between our two nations."

The die was cast. After a long vacillation that had allowed the Soviets to continue the construction of missile sites and the delivery of new missiles